Travel Agents: Taiwan — Rules Draft (v6.3.1 — TICKETS-ONLY · BALANCE-VALIDATED (re-sim); ready for the data rebuild + FTUE)

0. The pitch (read aloud, 20 seconds)

"You're rival travel agents building the best Taiwan food tour in one eating day. Ride between four regions to spread your name, dig ingredients from each market, and pile Buzz on the vendors you want — but your hype can't outrun your reputation. Win a vendor by out-hyping your rival on the spot — each one makes the next cheaper and becomes a stop on your tours. Your points come from Tour Tickets — line them up and finish them before dusk flips the street to the neon night market, and again before the last train's called. Most tour points is Top Agent."

1. Goal

Score the most points — and points come from one place only: your Tour Tickets (your win-pile 成團 minus half your lose-pile 遺珠 — §9).

Most = Top Agent. Vendors don't score — a vendor is your engine (each makes its region's ingredients cheaper) and the stop you assemble to complete tickets. (Reputation doesn't score either — it's the fuel that lets you make Buzz; see §4.)

2. Setup (teach while you set up)

1. Unfold the Taiwan map — four regions in a ring, North 北 · Central 中 · South 南 · East 東, an HSR spine linking North↔South. It holds the day-clock track (a dusk mark and a last-train mark), the Tours Completed counter (a small track with two Rave Review milestone marks — at your 2nd and 4th completed tour), the Reputation track (your Buzz-cap fuel — not a score), and — per region — a face-down vendor deck with face-up vendor slots (North 2, the others 1) and a face-down ingredient market deck. Set each Tours Completed marker to 0 and each Reputation marker to 2. (No score track — your score is your Tour Tickets, tallied at the end; §9.)
2. Sort each region's cards into a DAY deck and a NIGHT deck (drinks are the low-value vendors mixed into each); set the night decks aside for dusk. Shuffle each day vendor deck and day ingredient deck face-down into place. Ingredient decks use the 5-palette (N 豬肉 · C 茶 · S 海鮮 · E 米 + the common K 糖, in C & S only) plus a few event cards (§6) — including the two 排班保養 "Scheduled Maintenance" cards, one shuffled into the North NIGHT ingredient deck and one into the South NIGHT ingredient deck (they live in the night decks set aside for dusk). Fill the face-up vendor slots. Set out the Buzz supply (~24 @2p).

3. Tour Tickets — two decks, DAY and NIGHT: shuffle the DAY deck, draw 5 (rest to the box), reveal 3 as the shared ticket row (the other 2 form its draw pile). Set the NIGHT deck aside for dusk (drawn the same way then). A ticket's deck is its clock: DAY tickets are judged at dusk, NIGHT tickets at the last train (§8–§9).
4. Each agent takes an Agent Character (ability + flaw — read aloud, public) and a pawn. Every agent starts in Taipei (the North hub) — head office, the capital, the start of the HSR spine. (If the 里長伯 councillor is in play, he now names one home region at this point — his −1 discount works only there, and he pays +1 ingredient to Bribe anywhere else; see his mat + §5.) Your Larder starts empty and stays face-up all game.

3. How a turn works (the core loop — teach these six, then just play)

Do ONE action. Then if your Larder holds over 7 ingredients, discard down to 7 (to that region's market discard, which reshuffles in when the deck runs dry — ingredients are never removed from the game).

- VISIT THE LOCAL MARKET (where you stand) — flip the top 3 of this region's ingredient deck. Any event happens now (by its scope — §6), then is discarded. Keep up to 2 ingredients, discard the rest. Greedy Grab (optional): keep 1 more (3) → −1 Reputation (§4a).
- CONVENIENCE STORE (anywhere) — flip the top 1 card of any region's ingredient deck: an ingredient → take it; an event → it fires by its scope (§6). Greedy Grab (optional):

take the next card too (2 blind) → −1 Reputation (§4a). (Any region, no travel — the reliable way to grab the common K.)

- TRAVEL — move to a neighbouring region (HSR = North↔South), then flip the top 1 card of the region you arrive in: ingredient → take it; event → nothing, keep moving. You gain +1 Reputation — getting around spreads your name (§4).
- PROMOTE (with the vendor, in this region) — place 2 Buzz from the supply onto vendor(s) you're with here, so long as your total committed Buzz stays ≤ your Reputation (§4). Buzz stays on the card for all to see; your rival can pile on too.
- BRIBE A VENDOR — win a face-up vendor by out-hyping your rival, on the spot (§4–§5). (Winning any vendor moves the day-clock +1 and clears your Buzz off it — freeing your Reputation cap again.)
- LINE UP A TOUR TICKET — take one ticket from the face-up row of 3 (the current phase's DAY or NIGHT pool) as an open commitment; refill the row. You may only take one you haven't yet completed. It scores later into your win-pile / lose-pile (§8–§9) — your tickets are your whole score. (The agent lines up tours; the customers book them — completing a tour is the win.)

> **Agent Characters bend the rules.** Each mat carries one ability + one flaw for that agent alone (e.g. the competitive eater keeps all 3 on a Visit) — read every mat aloud at setup; a mat wins where it differs from the above.

4. Buzz & Reputation — the hype fight (the heart of it)

You show a vendor you want them with Buzz — you promise crowds and hype (your job: bring people to the food). - Buzz only ever sits in the supply or on a vendor — never in your hand. - To Buzz a vendor you must be standing in its region. - Both agents can pile Buzz on the same vendor — that's the fight, and it's where the game is won.

> Your hype can't outrun your reputation. Your total Buzz committed on the board may never exceed your current Reputation. Reputation is your standing (a marker on the Reputation track, starting at 2) — not a score, just how much Buzz you're allowed out at once. Travel +1 (getting around spreads your name) and a few events raise it; winning a vendor clears your Buzz off it, freeing your cap for the next campaign. So to out-escalate a contested vendor you first need the Reputation to cover the stack — travel builds the ammunition.

4a. Reputation sinks — greed costs you (the Greedy Grab)

When you source, you may grab one extra ingredient beyond your limit (an extra keep on a Visit, or a second card on a Convenience Store) — each grab costs −1 Reputation (you shoved to the front of the queue; word gets around). A couple of events also cost Reputation (a bad review, a mix-up).

> The one edge-case rule (say it once): your committed Buzz can never exceed your Reputation. So a Greedy Grab you can't afford is simply not allowed (you may only take it if it wouldn't drop your Reputation below your committed Buzz); and if an event drops your Reputation below your committed Buzz, immediately return Buzz from the board to the supply — your choice which — until you're back within your cap. (Reputation never goes below 0.)

5. Bribing a vendor (winning it over) — ONE rule for every vendor

To Bribe a face-up vendor, all at once: 1. be with the vendor, in its region; 2. hold at least 2 more Buzz on it than your rival (the majority, checked right now); 3. pay its ingredients, minus your region discounts (below).

> 里長伯's home turf (his mat only). The councillor's −1 discount works only in his home region; when he Bribes a vendor anywhere else, he pays +1 ingredient (of any one type) — an outsider's tax. His mat carries both icons.

Take the vendor to your tour — it's now a stop on your tours and an engine piece. If it completes a Tour Ticket you hold (its pattern is now met), flip that ticket to its done side and advance your Tours Completed counter (§5, Rave Reviews). Then clear ALL Buzz on it (yours and your rival's) back to the supply — freeing your Reputation cap — refill the slot from that region's current deck, and move the

day-clock +1 (§7). The vendor is locked from your rival. Winning a vendor scores no points on its own — points come only from completed Tour Tickets (§9).

> A vendor card is just two things: a value number and either a region icon or none. No perks, no bonus tracks — and the value is not a score. Its value only matters for the few Tour Tickets that ask for it (e.g. "vendors totalling ≥12 value") and marks out the big-ticket prizes. Each region icon you hold makes that region's ingredients 1 cheaper on future vendors — sign a couple of Southern stalls and the next barely needs oysters (that's the engine). Drinks and the apex ★ trophies carry no icon (drinks = cheap low-value filler; ★ = the top-value marquee get, no ramp). Buzz is never discounted, so the hype fight — gated by your Reputation — not the ingredients, is what gates your next big win. Night stalls cost meaningfully more than day stalls, and every night name needs ingredients from two regions — so your one-region discount ramp helps you afford the big night names but never zeroes them out: even a strong engine still has to source and travel for that second region's ingredient it can't discount away. Day builds the ramp; night is where it pays off.
>
> Outraced, not robbed. If your rival out-hypes you, your Buzz just fizzles back to the supply — you keep every ingredient you sourced, and a fresh vendor comes out. You never seize a place.
>
> Rave Reviews (milestones). As you complete tours, your Tours Completed counter climbs. The first time YOU reach your 2nd completed tour → +1 Reputation; the first time YOU reach your 4th → take 1 ingredient of your choice + your next Bribe costs 1 less ingredient. Each is a one-time boon, and each agent earns

their own (crossing a mark never pumps the leader — you can only ever earn your own). Your tour's getting noticed — a little tailwind, never points.

6. The market decks & events (the island doesn't sit still)

Each region's market is a face-down deck of its signature ingredient (+ the common K, in two of the four regions) and a few event cards (mostly hazards). Working a market — a Visit or a Convenience Store — fires any flipped event straight away, by its scope; a card flipped as you arrive on a Travel does nothing. - Hazards (the majority) — a typhoon, a "完售 SOLD OUT" sign, scooter gridlock. They tax or delay — never destroy what you hold, never cost a whole turn. - Boons (the minority) — a festival that hands out Buzz, a kind auntie, or a vendor suddenly gets hot (★ below).

The scope tag — who the event hits, measured from the region the card came out of: ⦿ You (just the flipper) · ⬢ This region (everyone standing in the drawn region) · ➤ Next door (someone in a neighbour). Worked example: on a Visit you stand in the region you flipped, so ⬢ hits you; on a Convenience Store you're often elsewhere, so ⬢ hits whoever stands in the region you flipped — flip a rival's region and a scoped hazard can land on them. Never a personal attack — just the island living its life.

排班保養 "Scheduled Maintenance" (a table-wide event — the whole island feels it). A special island-wide event card (its own banner frame — not a ⦿/⬢/➤ scoped card): the HSR is down

> for everyone. Place it on the HSR spine as a reminder. Until the start of your next turn, North and South are not linked — everyone Travels the long way around the ring (N→C→S or N→E→S). Then discard it and the HSR reopens. "The high-speed rail's down for scheduled maintenance — slow road for everyone, you included." Warm, not a strike — the island, not a rival, closes the line.
>
> ★ Star vendors. Some night-market names carry a printed ★ (a real Michelin / Bib-Gourmand nod), carry the top value, carry no region icon (a pure trophy, not an engine piece), and sit one apex per region — the rotating prize both agents chase (they finish the value-tickets fastest and are the marquee "get"). A boon can also drop a ★ Star token on a vendor, making it worth +2 value to whoever wins it.

7. The day-clock — Day → Night (every vendor you win moves it)

It's one eating day. The day-clock climbs +1 every time anyone Bribes a vendor — food or drink alike. It has two marks (2p: dusk = the 5th table-wide vendor win · last train = the 10th; the marks grow with more players): - Act I — Daytime 白天: morning food + the day's drinks. Cheap and low-contest at first — build your discount ramp and stake early positions. Daytime Tour Tickets are on offer. - DUSK (the day-clock hits the dusk mark) — the street turns over. In one flip: judge every claimed DAYTIME ticket (completed → win-pile · unfinished → lose-pile — §9); then clear the entire day layer island-wide — every face-up and face-down day vendor deck AND day ingredient deck — and replace it with each region's night decks (a

neon recolour, run event-heavier). Swap the ticket row to the nighttime pool. You keep your Larder. Any unclaimed day vendor is gone. - Act II — Night Market 夜市: the big night-market stalls — expensive, fought-over, the ★ apex per region. This is where the tour is won.

(The faster you all win vendors, the faster the day moves — a built-in catch-up for a slow, tall player.)

8. Ending the trip — the last train home

When the day-clock hits the last-train mark (2p: the 10th vendor win), everyone catches the last train: finish the current round, play one more full round, and stop. (Backstop: if a region's deck empties, its slot isn't refilled until the next flip; if all decks dry island-wide, the phase ends then. If one win trips dusk and the last train at once, resolve dusk first, then the end check.)

9. Scoring — reveal your piles and tally once

Your score is your Tour Tickets, and nothing else. Reveal your two piles and tally once, at game end: - + the printed value of each ticket in your WIN pile (成團) — the tours that ran. - − floor(value ÷ 2) for each ticket in your LOSE pile (遺珠) — half its own value, rounded down — the ones that got away.

Tickets are sorted into your own two piles as each phase ends (DAY at dusk, NIGHT at the last train — §7–§8); nothing changes during play, and you tally once.

Vendors do NOT score — every vendor you won was your engine (cheaper ingredients) and a stop you used to complete tickets; its value was never points. Reputation does NOT score — it was your Buzz-cap fuel all game, nothing more.

Most points wins → Top Agent. Ties: most vendors, then most regions covered, then fewest tickets in your LOSE pile (遺珠).

10. The warm-tone reminders (margin asides, not rules)

- You're promoting Taiwan's food — winning a vendor is out-hyping your rival to earn their blessing, never taking from them. "Bribe" is the cheeky word; the deed is a warm hard sell, not corruption.
- Events are the island living its life — never sacred customs for laughs; a Convenience-Store event on your rival is the island doing it, a shared groan, never a spiteful strike. Dish and vendor names stay real (Tâi-lô + 繁體); the comedy is the caper gag and your own gluttony.

Iconography — the flip-to legend

Every glyph on the cards, tokens, and board. Shapes are drawn, so they read by shape + 繁體 label, never colour alone.

Ingredients (the 5 tokens)



Pork 豬肉
North signature · hexagon



Tea 茶
Central signature · triangle



Seafood 海鮮
South signature · square



Rice 米
East signature · circle



Sugar 糖
The common (C & S only) · beam

The four regions



North 北
vermilion · triangle · pork



Central 中
jade · diamond · tea



South 南
amber · circle · seafood



East 東
indigo · square · rice

Event scope — who it hits



⊙ You
self — only the flipper



⬢ This region
everyone standing in the drawn region



➤ Next door
spills into a neighbouring region

Day / Night

Day 日 · 早
warm morning layer — breakfast run

Night 夜 · 市
neon night-market layer (after dusk)

Currencies & scoring

Buzz 讚
the hype you pile on a vendor

★ Apex / Star
top prize per region; a Star adds value

Prestige
a vendor's point value (your score)

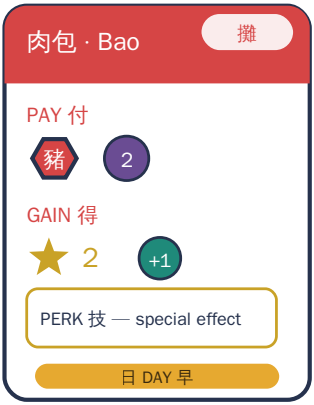
Reputation 譽
your standing — scores by final position

The two ticket piles

成團 · Win pile
tours that ran: gain printed value

遺珠 · Lose pile
got away: lose half the value

Vendor card — layout key



① Header band = region colour + emblem + dish name

② PAY 付 = ingredient chips (shape+繁體) + Buzz needed

③ GAIN 得 = Prestige (★) + Reputation (譽) + perk

④ PERK 技 = the vendor's special bonus

⑤ Phase ribbon = day 日 / night 夜 (which layer)

Top-right pill = venue tier (攤 stall · 小吃 · 名店)

★ printed = an apex / Star vendor (top prize)